Prachanda, summarizing the experiences of the CPN-M's 'people's war' in 1997, stated that the first year of the armed struggle had established a firm relationship 'between the revolutionaries of South Asia, including India … [the] Maoist people's war is getting support from tens of millions of people in India, who are waging national liberation struggles in various states … similarly the communist revolutionaries of Bangladesh and Sri Lanka are giving support to the Nepalese people's war.'[16]

Conspicuously absent among all those allegedly supporting the CPN-M's 'people's war' was China. The party sparingly accused the new Chinese leadership under Deng Xiaoping of being revisionist, but Prachanda stated in one of his writings,

> For the masses there is no alternative to rebellion and revolution, given the objective background of exploitation, repression and poverty prevalent in the semi-feudal and semi-colonial countries of the Third World. In Nepal, our first effort was to correctly grasp the science of Marxism-Leninism-Maoism. For this, we strove to link ourselves with the arduous and challenging ideological struggle waged by the genuine communist revolutionaries of the world against the Chinese counter-revolution after the death of Comrade Mao Zedong. Taking the synthesis of the Great Proletarian Cultural Revolution, the highest expression of conscious class struggle, as our starting point, we delved into serious study.[17]

Li Onesto, an American supporter and writer for the Chicago-based *Revolutionary Worker* weekly, echoed the same views in her book about the war in Nepal. 'The Maoists in Nepal denounce the current Chinese regime for overthrowing and dismantling socialism after Mao's death. The Chinese government has made clear that it supports the efforts to crush the insurgency, but China would be extremely concerned if India invaded Nepal to prevent the Maoists from seizing power.'[18]

It was far-fetched to suggest that India would 'invade' Nepal. India had other means of influencing Nepalese politics, for instance, through its close relationship with the Nepali Congress and other aboveground politicians. The Chinese, on their part, accused the CPN-M of distorting Mao's ideology and 'besmirching the name of Mao by calling their indiscriminate killing of civilians a People's War … on February 3, 2005 Chinese Foreign Ministry spokesman Kong Quan expressed his indignation at foreign media who call Nepal's anti-government rebels "Maoists."'[19]

China's relationship with Nepal has always been motivated by geopolitical considerations rather than ideology, by the desire to build a strategic corridor in the Himalayas in order to counter India's influence in